

Dahl 1972 RG Notes

Dahl, Robert A. *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition*.
New Haven: Yale University Press, 1971.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- “Given a regime in which the opponents of the government cannot openly and legally organize into political parties in order to oppose the government in free and fair elections, what conditions favor or impede a transformation into a regime in which they can? That is the question with which this book is concerned.”
- Democratization and development of a public opposition are separate forces. We consider two metrics: the extent to which an opposition is allowed to reasonably exist, and the size of the franchise granted government participation. Two dimensions become public contestation and the right to participate

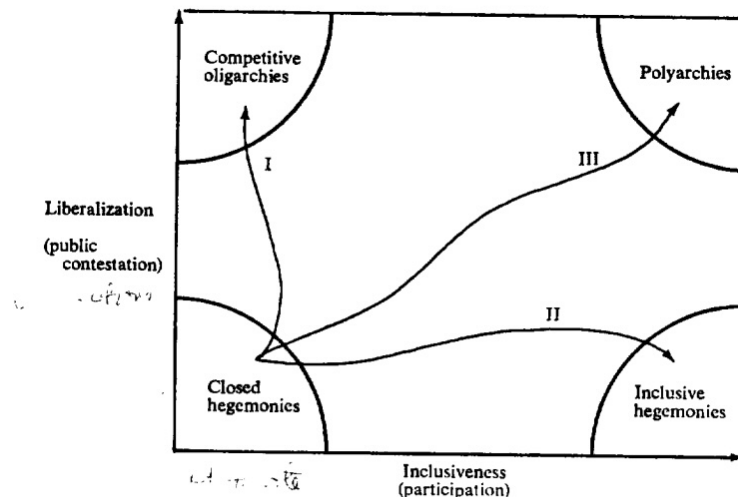


FIGURE 1.2 Liberalization, Inclusiveness, and Democratization

Democratization represented by path III

- “The greater the conflict between government and opposition, the more likely that each will seek to deny opportunities to the other to participate effectively in policy making. To put it another way, the greater the conflict between a government and its opponents, the more costly it is for each to tolerate each other”

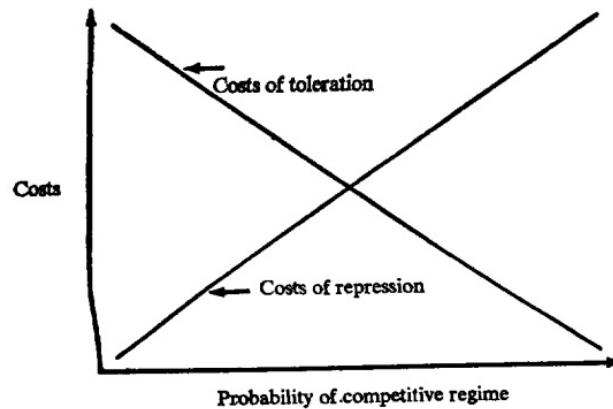


FIGURE 1.4

- As the franchise expands, candidates change their alignments/platforms/beliefs: need to seek support of the newly-enfranchised groups. May often result in the formation of new parties (especially workers'/Labour parties or the like, as well as socialist sentiment) to appeal to these groups. Also drives a change in the structures of parties, as they need to be able to better connect with a larger group: introduces hierarchy, bureaucracy, etc.
- Three primary paths to polyarchy:
 1. Liberalization precedes inclusiveness: England, Sweden. Most common, more peaceful as groups slowly integrate and existing ties hold cohesion. Supported by mutual security that exists at the beginning, and then can be maintained. (Very close to A&R “Why the West...”)
 2. Inclusiveness precedes liberalization: Wiemar Republic. Less common and more dangerous: mutual security system does not exist at the beginning of the process, and so instability may perpetuate.
 3. Shortcut: closed hegemony abruptly transforms into a polyarchy by a sudden grant of suffrage and rights of contestation. France 1789-1792. Few examples of working; no mutual security and little time to adapt to things. (Extremely reflective of Huntington argument, although Dahl focuses more on the lack of mutual security rather than a lack of expressive participatory opportunities)
- Polyarchies often “inaugurated” either within an independent nation-state (transformed via reform, revolution, or military conquest) or in a dependent country subject to another state (transformed via reform or revolution). Peace lends future stability: polyarchies developed through reform are more likely to be viewed as legitimate

- Because suppression requires resources (both for violent and nonviolent means), regimes with limited resources may be more likely to tolerate the opposition, as the relative costliness of intolerance increases. This is counterintuitive in many senses to existing arguments that wealth would drive stability: rather, wealth drives state capacity, which in turn allows for repression/hegemony.
- Effective and dispersed government requires that means of repression/violence/etc. are available to *both* the government and the opposition: asymmetric availability results in monopolistic governance while symmetric unavailability results in uniformity (but could perhaps be more unstable, depending). Ideal for dispersement/neutralization for *both* access to violence and access to socioeconomic sanctions; hegemony thrives when both are monopolized
- While classic liberal theory suggested that competitive politics could not be sustained without competitive market-based economics, Dahl disagrees that this universally holds true – rather, the motivating factor in hegemony is whether or not there is a highly centralized economy (which is itself dissuaded by competitive politics)
- “The chances that a country will develop and maintain a competitive political regime (and, even more so, a polyarchy) depend up on the extent to which the country’s society and economy:
 1. Provide literacy, education, and communication
 2. Create a pluralistic rather than a centrally dominated social order
 3. Prevent extreme inequalities
 among the politically relevant strata of the country.”
- Polyarchy arises out of advanced economies, but advanced economies also may be more prone to severe inequality.
 - One argument here involves the distribution of political resources and skills. Those with the means to do so will attempt to bend political systems in their favor; the distribution of those means is itself endogenous and largely favors to those with the means in the first place. Advanced economies lead to less inequality of political resources – does not imply strict equality, but does imply parity, which in turn supports both inclusion and contestation
 - Alternative explanation suggests that the driving force here is the power of resentment from excluded groups. Regimes may capitulate to *some* demands for greater equality, but not necessarily all; doing so may be sufficient to gain the support of excluded groups even if full equality is not actually achieved. Possible “performative” or signaling impact here

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Three necessary conditions for democracy – citizens must be able to:
 1. Formulate their preferences
 2. Signify their preferences to their fellow citizens and the government by individual and collective action
 3. Have their preferences weighed equally in the conduct of the government – weighted with no discrimination because of the content or source of the preferences
- Regime type has consequences. (Argues specifically for this claim in chapter 2 – although quite obvious, may be a useful early example of such)
- When military capacity is high and organized, polyarchy is impossible unless the military is sufficiently depoliticized such that it has neither intent nor ability to interfere with political discourse or dynamics.
- Farming societies largely differentiated into traditional peasant society, defined largely by hegemony, or a free farmer society, more aligned towards polyarchy.
- Though socioeconomic development seems in part to be linked to the prevalence of polyarchy – and it seems plausible that there exist upper and lower thresholds of economic development beyond which the probability of polyarchy remains constant – the relationship is neither clear, nor statedly causal, nor incredibly strong, nor without exception.
- Developed economies allow workers to be literate and more-educated, which in turn can expand their potential inclusion into the polyarchy – dual-directional effect. Advanced economies cause pluralistic social orders, which in turn cause demands for a competitive political system (under one causal chain).
- “In an advanced economy, long-run performance under threat or coercion is less productive at all levels than a more willing performance based upon voluntary compliance.”

4 Connections

- “When hegemonic regimes and competitive oligarchies move toward polyarchy they increase the opportunities for effective participation and contestation and hence the number of individuals, groups, and interests whose preferences have to be considered in policymaking.” Indirect connection to Huntington 1968: increases participation, which per Huntington should result in instability unless there are additional institutions to handle it. Suggestion is that transition to polyarchy must involve a non-trivial movement towards institutional development as well.
- More Huntington 1968: agrees (indirectly) that parties begin to move away from

tribal/familial/otherwise native sources of power and authority, and instead are replaced by those which are appealing to the middle classes

- Broad-scale oppression (i.e., Holocaust, USSR atrocities, etc.) do not happen in polyarchies, largely because the low barriers to contestation both allow marginalize groups to better defend themselves politically and preemptively dissuade the state from pursuing or proposing any such aggressive policies
- Liberalization preceding inclusiveness – very much tied to A&R Why the West Extended the Franchise; essentially the same mechanism. Shortcut – very much tied to Huntington, although Dahl focuses more on mutual security than effective participation. See “three paths to polyarchy” in second section.

5 My Critiques

- One central claim seems to be that competitive politics universally dissuades coercion/repression etc. There is a world, though, where that argument does not necessarily stand. For example, in a reverse causal chain, if coercive capacity was quite high – such that the rents of holding office were similarly high – we might expect there to be more competition endogenously.